

32 Ways to Refocus on the Important « Far Beyond The Stars

The most successful people have only a few priorities. Here's how to refocus when you lose track of yours.

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The inconvenient truth of entrepreneurship.

I have a confession to make, I've been working too hard.

The whole idea of working for myself was so I could have more time to live life, remember?

Well, over the last two weeks I got carried away with my entrepreneurship. I've been working over 40 hours a week on the blog and my next e-book. This is far too much time to be spending on my minimalist business.

I was supposed to be living the minimalist work week to the fullest, and concentrating on my real priorities: Yoga, Cooking, Writing, and Reading.

Instead I've been working all day, cooking fattier foods, and I had totally forgotten about yoga for a week.

I've got to refocus, maybe you do too?

Everyone loses focus on their priorities occasionally.

This is okay though, everyone loses focus on their priorities once in awhile. Occasionally it's beneficial to lose the balance in their life in order to achieve greatness in one direction.

But after working hard in one area, there comes a time when it's necessary to refocus on what you've identified as being truly important. For more on identifying the important see: [The Stunning Truth About Focusing on the Important](#).

This is why I've compiled a list, below, of 32 ways to focus on the important. I hope it can help you re-find the focus in your life.

I'm going to be refocusing in the coming weeks.

As some of you know, I'm working on a new e-book called *Minimalist Business*. The e-book explores my journey to creating a low-overhead business which supports my location independent lifestyle.

I'm writing this e-book because I've received hundreds of emails about business side of my work on *The Art of Being Minimalist*. These emails have given me many ideas to think about as I did my best to help everyone who emailed me create their own minimalist businesses.

I hope it can help you achieve the same kind of life, if you're interested.

In order to get the e-book done, and maintain focus in my life, I'm going slow down the schedule here at Far Beyond The Stars to two stories per week. This way I can work on making two posts twice as useful to you, and also have time to work on completing the e-book.

On to the focus!

Feel free to apply one or a few of these to your life, but don't try to do them all at once. Definitely feel free to bookmark this page and return to it whenever you find yourself losing focus.

Here are 32 ways to refocus on your priorities.

1. Slow down. The best way to refocus on your priorities is to slow down. Take 10 deep breathes. Walk slower through life and appreciate every moment. You'll start to see clarity when you take time to appreciate every moment.

2. Stop checking email. If you read my post on *Timejacking*, you know my opinion on email: it's not as necessary as you think. Set two (or even one) specific times to check email during your day. This can save you up to 3 hours of time sitting in front of your inbox waiting for messages to come, so you can react to them. Turn this around, and you'll start to focus on your priorities and create great work. I've been checking email less (trying for one time per day as much as possible) for a number of weeks, and my productivity has exploded.

3. Change up your routine. Turn your routine on it's head. If you exercise in the mornings, try exercising at night. If you work during the week, try working on the weekends or at night instead. If you walk down 5th Avenue every day on your way to work, try walking on 6th Avenue instead. If you always go out

to eat, try cooking at home instead.

4. Disconnect from the internet. Turn off your wireless router, or unplug your Ethernet cable, and just sit there. At first you'll go crazy without being able to constantly click around on Facebook. It's okay, you'll be fine. Before 1990 no one had Internet in their homes, remember? Let alone Internet in their pockets! You'll survive. Just sit and stare at a wall until you're able to refocus on your priorities.

5. Write your priorities down. This is so incredibly important. Take out a sheet of paper, or open a blank document on your computer, and simply write down your priorities. I like to keep them to 4 or less. These are the things that are really important to you. These are passions, not obligations.

6. Take a few days off. Nothing fixes focus like a good long weekend. Take a few days off and do something fun. Don't think about work. Don't do any work. Just focus on having fun, or creating something that you enjoy. When you get back to work you'll have a fresh mind and be able to refocus on your priorities.

7. Take a walk. A good long walk can do wonders if you can't focus. The repetitive motion of your feet has a way of centering the left and right hemispheres of your brain. Just pick a direction and start walking, don't have a destination, just walk for the journey.

8. Go to the beach for a day. I love going to the beach. It's a great place to sit in the sun and let your worries wash away. If you don't have a beach near you, a park can do too, (but beaches are more awesome.) Bring some sandwiches and spiked punch. Don't forget your sunscreen! Definitely forget your cellphone.

9. Up your intensity. Sometimes the best way to refocus is to take everything to the next level. Take one of your priorities and spend 80% of your time doing it. I plan on doing this with Yoga in the next few weeks. By spending all of your time, you'll be able to refocus on your priority and take it to the next level.

10. Work somewhere new. If you're used to working in an office, or in your home, make the decision to change your location. Work from a coffee shop or the library. Go to a friend's house and work together. Take your work out on the porch and work in the sun, or go to the park.

11. Hang out with different people. We can sometimes fall into a routines of hanging out with the same good folks all the time. The trouble is, this can lead to social stagnation. Try hanging out with new people once in awhile. This will open you up to new ideas and you'll have new experiences.

12. Sleep more. This is a no-brainer. The studies all show that we don't get as much sleep as we need. Take a few days and catch up on your rest. Sleep for 9 hours a night instead of 6. You'll start to notice your priorities come into focus when you have enough rest.

13. Eat good food. We are what we eat, literally. And yet some people eat garbage from the take-out. Don't do this! Try cooking dinners at home every day for a week (perhaps consider doing this for the rest of your life.) Use fresh vegetables, beans, nuts, berries, etc. Eat fresh fruit for breakfast in order to have more energy. When you eat better you'll overcome obstacles with much less effort.

14. Sit in silence. Simply sit in silence for 30 minutes. Don't worry about meditating. Sit on a comfortable pillow, or in a chair, close your eyes and let the thoughts pass through your brain. A time-out like that can change your thinking and help you refocus.

15. Kill your bad habits. Choose one bad habit and take it to the guillotine. Just stop doing whatever you hate about yourself. There are so many things that humans compulsively do that are bad for us. When we have the courage to tell ourselves no we can free up space to focus on what we really want to accomplish. Some bad habits you may have: TV, smoking, drinking, Twitter all day, email, negativity, pessimism, driving.

16. Stop worrying so much. Anxiety is simply failing over and over and over again in advance. Tell yourself to stop worrying. The simple reason for this is that worrying doesn't do any good. It doesn't help to guess at what the outcome of an action will be. Make a decision about what you think the outcome will be and stick with it. Maybe it'll work out, maybe it won't. At least you didn't spend 5 hours chewing up your stomach anticipating your own failure.

17. Throw out the plan. Plans are just guesses. Too many people spend 80% of their time planning and half of the time they never get to the actual execution. I'd like to let you in on a secret: execution is everything. The plan isn't necessary if you don't do anything. In most cases you can do something without a plan. Cut out the preparation and start making things happen.

18. Read for new ideas. Take a day and go to the bookstore. Find a great book. If you need suggestions, I've [read a bunch of books so far this year](#). All of them were very good. Now, sit down and read the book. Slowly let the ideas flow off the page and into you. This will rejuvenate your focus on the important.

19. Turn off the TV. If you know me, you know I hate the TV. Two years ago I helped my roommate paint three of them and turn them into an art

installation. Two weeks ago I helped my girlfriend finally sell her flatscreen. The average American watched 5 hours of TV a day in 2008 (according to The Story of Stuff), that's 35 hours a week. Tell me there are better things you could be doing with that time.

20. Take a mini-retirement. There's no sense in wasting the prime of your life working yourself to death. Save up a few thousand dollars and go incommunicado. Rent a boat and sail down slowly down the coast. Rent a beach house in Mexico and disappear for a month or two. Trust me, the world will be here when you get back.

21. Move somewhere new. So many people never make the decision to leave their home town. It can be one of the best decisions you ever make it leave a place one you've been there for awhile. Pick somewhere and go there. Leave behind all of your crap, you don't need it. Just go somewhere before it's too late.

22. Radically change your diet. If you're eating pancakes every morning, try eating fresh fruit. If you eat steak for dinner, try eating tofu. There are a million ways to radically change your diet. You are what you eat, so when you transform your diet you transform yourself.

23. Declutter your living space. Take a day and get rid of clutter. Find a home for every object that you own. Put things in drawers or closets. If you can't find homes for everything, you need to get rid of some things. Make a box and put things in it. Take these things and donate them to someone needs them.

24. Limit your work schedule. We work too much. The worst part is, we can usually manage to fit our work into as long as we give ourselves to complete our jobs. No one ever achieved great things by working 80 hours a week for an entire year. If you normally work 60 hours, reduce your schedule to 40. If you work 40, reduce it to 20. Once I get to 10 hours a week of work, I'm going to try and reduce it down to 4 as soon as possible. I bet you can get the same amount of work done by strategically batching requests and eliminating the unessential.

25. Turn off your smartphone. What a terrible idea, giving yourself the ability to be constantly in touch via email. (full disclosure, I do have an iPhone. I mainly use it for capturing ideas via Evernote, taking photos, and communicating with readers via Twitter during set batched intervals.) Turn your smartphone off for periods at a time, if you can't get rid of it completely. You'll notice a world of difference, and you'll be able to focus on the important.

26. Leave your phone at home. Go out into the world and leave your phone

at home. Trust me, you'll be able to tell what time it is. You can ask somebody! It's important to disconnect from people once in awhile. If you're constantly available, you're simply going to be reacting to requests. Bonus: let every single call you receive go to voicemail first, then batch call everyone back at one set time per day. This will save you tons of time if you're a heavy phone user.

27. Rearrange your house. Take a day and change how your home is arranged. Or maybe even just your living room or office. Put the couch on the other wall. Take the TV and throw it out the window. Consult a Feng shui expert (or ask the Internet) and make sure your space is obeying the right rules. When you're done, the new perspective will help you refocus.

28. Go vagabonding. Put the essentials for survival in a bag. Book a ticket somewhere and just go. It doesn't matter where you go, just go. Email the hostel and book a few nights, then take off from there. Don't have a destination, don't go see touristy stuff, just live somewhere new every single day. Read Rolf Potts's awesome book [Vagabonding](#) for more on how to have this amazing experience.

29. Read different blogs. We fall into reading the same bloggers over and over again, but that can be a trap. I try to write about new things, and delve deeper into topics, but inevitably I'm still me. Other bloggers are still them. After reading a blogger for a number of months, you might find yourself just reading out of obligation. Try reading new bloggers to change things up.

30. Stop reading the paper. Newspapers are dead. Most of their employees have taken huge pay-cuts over the last few years. Most of their writers are forced to write about topics that they don't have expertise in and don't interest them. This leads to sloppy writing and boring stories. Stop reading newspapers, you won't be missing much.

31. Eliminate obligations. People tend to collect obligations like we collect junk. The problem is that sometimes we don't take stock to see if we're getting anything out of them. Take a moment and make a list of everything you're obligated to do every week. Now strike out everything that you hate doing. This can free up a huge amount of time.

32. Let it all go. Finally, just let it go. The world can do without you for awhile. Just relax and let things happen when they happen. Don't worry so much, or you'll get gray hair and you'll need anti-depressants. When you let it all go, it's only a matter of time before you start to refocus on your priorities and start to make great work.

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Here are some links that will help you:

[Be Your Own Guru](#) by Jonathan Fields.

[The Joy of Walking](#) by Leo Babauta.

[Paying it Way Forward](#) by Colin Wright.

[The Most Important Blog Post You'll Never Read](#) by Glenn Allsopp.

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How do you refocus on your priorities?

If this article helped you, I'd love if you'd take 10 seconds and use your favorite method to share it.

Thank you.

Excerpted from *32 Ways to Refocus on the Important « Far Beyond The Stars | Augmented Humanity,
Second Selves, and Cybernetic Yoga*

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